

Post-war Light Aircraft

Despite World War II shutting down civilian production for five years, the light aircraft that were built in the 1940s set the pattern for the next 60 years. They featured a light, simple, monocoque fuselage; increasingly metal construction; and efficient, horizontally opposed air-cooled engines. Many 1940s aircraft remain in use in the 21st century, while others have been mildly modified and put back into production.



◁ Boeing-Stearman PT-17/N2S Kaydet 1940

Origin USA

Engine 450 hp Pratt & Whitney R-985 Wasp Junior air-cooled 9-cylinder radial

Top speed 140 mph (225 km/h)

Designed in 1934 and built in thousands in WWII, many Stearmans were sold off after the war. They were fitted with more powerful engines and used for agricultural duties like crop-dusting, as well as aerobatic shows.



▷ Luscombe 8A Silvaire Ragwing 1941

Origin USA

Engine 65 hp Continental A-65 air-cooled flat-4

Top speed 128 mph (206 km/h)

Don Luscombe's Model 8 was radical in 1937 for its monocoque fuselage and all-metal structure. With its new horizontally opposed engine, it was an early post-war pacesetter.



△ Aeronca Champion 1944

Origin USA

Engine 65-90 hp Continental A65-C90 air-cooled flat-4

Top speed 100 mph (160 km/h)

The tandem-seat "Champ" was such an effective design that it reentered production in 2007. Speedier than the rival Piper Cub, it could be flown solo from the front seat, giving better visibility.

▷ Fairchild UC-61K Argus Mk3 1944

Origin USA

Engine 200 hp Fairchild Ranger air-cooled 6-cylinder inverted in-line

Top speed 124 mph (200 km/h)

Popular as personal transport after the war, 306 of this rugged development of the 1932 Fairchild F-24 were built for the RAF Air Transport Auxiliary. They had the powerful Ranger engine and four seats.



△ Auster J/1 Autocrat 1945

Origin UK

Engine 100 hp Blackburn Cirrus Minor or 145 hp de Havilland Gypsy Major air-cooled 4-cylinder inverted in-line

Top speed 120 mph (193 km/h)

The Autocrat was a successful three-seater light aircraft derived from a wartime observation design. It is still flown widely for leisure in the 21st century. This example is fitted with a long-range belly tank.